Hilti Group: Building a Sales Strategy through Data Analytics

"With Champion 2020, we have built a solid foundation and are now poised to reap what we have sown, to significantly accelerate our sales growth and gain new market share."

- Dr. Christoph Loos, CEO, Hilti Group

On February 18, 2026, Maria Kgangbe, Territory Manager for Hilti sat down at her desk in Circle Square, Manchester. In a few minutes she would meet with her international strategy team to discuss the sales strategy for 2027. The company had set a goal of increasing sales revenue by 14% by year-end 2027, up from 12% percent in 2025. As the news alert flashed across her screen, Maria contemplated the impact Prime Ministers broadcast informing the country of another economic quarter of little growth in the UK economy.

As expected, this news dominated discussions throughout the meeting leaving the team concerned as to how the devised plan could mitigate the impact of turbulence within the building industry and the UK economy. In addition, Hilti also faced a global economic slowdown and a weakened construction market with lengthening sales cycles. Whilst the full impact would be difficult to gage, consideration must now be given to how this situation could be best navigated. Any downturn would eventually impact the entire industry and could potentially lead to some competitors exiting certain foreign markets completely. Mariah informed her team that as the corona virus crisis had created unprecedented uncertainty 2020, the continued downturn of the economy due to Brexit, the war in Ukraine, and the radical "new era" economic agenda that has destabilised the economy in recent months as a result of US tariffs, it was critical that Hilti figure out how to protect and increase revenues and not default to just containing or cutting costs. Indeed, the ability to grow would separate the leaders from the pack when the global economy rebounds, as it eventually will. Mariah and her team needed to create a sales plan to succeed in this difficult market environment. How could Hilti leverage its position using the data sources at their disposal? What was the right strategy to support the sales team? What makes a good sales region? Ultimately, the team needed to determine where and how Hilti should deploy its sales resources in 2027.

Once sales leaders have stabilised the immediate situation, they must turn to what it will take to sustain momentum despite social distancing around the globe and invest to rebound in the recovery. Hilti will have the opportunity to come out of the crisis as winners. That was the message that Mariah tried to instil into the team. However, with delays in the global supply chain leading to delivery cancellations, resources at a premium, and travel becoming challenging, Hilti has many challenges to tackle right away. Sales leaders, especially in B2B markets, will determine how this crisis can be turned into an opportunity.

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Company Background

Hilti Corporation (Hilti Aktiengesellschaft or Hilti AG, also known as the Hilti Group) is a Liechtenstein multinational company that develops, manufactures, and markets products for the construction, building maintenance, energy and manufacturing industries, mainly to the professional end-user. It concentrates mainly on anchoring systems, fire protection systems, installation systems, measuring and detection tools (such as laser levels, range meters and line lasers), power tools (such as hammer drills, demolition hammers, diamond drills, cordless electric drills, heavy angle drills, power saws) and related software and services.

Hilti stands for quality, innovation and direct customer relationships resulting in about 250,000 individual customer contacts each day. Based in Schaan, Liechtenstein, the company has 30,000 employees around the world who contribute to making construction work simpler, faster and safer while inspiring customers every single day with technologically leading products, systems, software and services. Since its establishment in 1941, Hilti has become a global business, based in more than 120 countries worldwide. The group under the leadership of its CEO, Dr Christoph Loos, is focused on delivering its mission, to grow as a global leader and create products that are innovative, different and stand out from the rest.

Figure 1: Hilti Mission Statement, 2020

The organisation believes strongly in developing close and trusted relationships with its customers. Its success can be attributed to the operation of the direct sales model which engages customer worldwide with 15,000 Hilti team members. In addition to a string of Hilti stores where the construction industry is able to directly buy Hilti products, team members work closely with customer online, on the phone and on site. Many ideas for improvements are developed directly on construction sites while talking to customers. If there is an on-site challenge for which no Hilti solution exists, one will be developed. This is why the company invests approximately 6% of sales each year in research and development. Sales reps and field engineers go out onsite to help identify solutions – whether it is choosing the right kind of nail or designing a rebar system for a major metro system. As part of a holistic approach, the data collected by the sales reps and field engineers is fed back to Hilti design labs with the aim of improving current provisions and creating better and more daring projects. This process is further enhanced by leveraging close working partnerships with external specialist suppliers who ensure that products and services conform to the high-quality standards expected. Hilti develops its own products through its factories in Europe, Mexico, the USA, India and China.

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History

Hilti has come a long way since the company was founded in 1941 by Martin and Eugene Hilti in Schaan, Liechtenstein. The breakthrough came in 1957 in the form of the DX 100 (see Figure 3) – the first powder-actuated tool in the world, which marked global prominence for technological advancement. This was followed by further successes such as the launch of the first electro-pneumatic hammer drill, the TE series (see Figure 4), which has now evolved into the most comprehensive series of tools. With a reputable portfolio of products, the organisation focused on international expansion throughout the 1970s and 80s, establishing centres in Germany and Scotland. Formations of market regions in America, Africa, Asia and Europe followed swiftly, ensuring that the customer needs from regional markets could be better served. The continuous build-up of international markets continued during the 90s and further solidified Hilti's market dominance with new branches in Russia and South America. True globalisation was further achieved at the IT level in 2002, with the launch of globally standardised business processes and data, providing a foundation for substantial gains in efficiency and productivity.

Hilti made further enhancements by streamlining its portfolio into three fully functioning product divisions; anchor systems, direct fastening, and drilling and demolition. Each division comprises the functions of product management, R&D, logistics, controlling, purchasing, and production.

Corporate Strategy

The focus of the strategic objective of Hilti is formed around sustainable value creation through market leadership and differentiation; market leadership in terms of relative market share, and differentiation via the direct sale of the company's portfolio. More specifically, the company is focused on emphasising four proven strategic fields of activity; continuous innovation, direct access to and partnership with customers in the construction industry, operational excellence to ensure continuous position as market leader and, a high-performing global team. The following diagram presents the business model adopted by Hilti.

Figure 2: Hilti Business Model, 2022

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Product Overview

Hilti design, develop, distribute and maintain over 45,000 products as well as market leading software and solutions. All the products and solutions are designed to make constructions sites safer and more productive. The products are highly innovative and have won many awards for design and innovation.

The areas of Hilti products include powder-actuated fastening, drilling and demolition, diamond coring and cutting, measuring, firestop, screw fastening, adhesive and mechanical anchoring to name a few. Every product is backed with world-class research, software, service and support.

"In research and technology, we have the opportunity to work on the latest technology, like in a kind of incubator and bring this into the products and that is pure fun."

- Andreas Bong, Head of Corporate Research and Development

With such a large product portfolio Hilti need to segment their sales force to key trades and applications so that their Account Managers can become "*experts*" in their given area. This is achieved by them focusing on key trades and building applications. There are four core trade groups that Hilti focus on as well as multiple other specialist trades. Within each trade group there are several key applications that these customers do every day as part of their core business. Hilti has many products including tools, inserts and fixings that will support the whole process from start to finish in these applications. The goal is for the Account Manager to be able to sell the whole product solution for a give application rather than an individual tool or fixing.

Go to market approach

Hilti's sales approach is built on having a partnership based on direct access with its customers. Practically this translates to a direct sales forces, that go out and physically visit customers both onsite and at their corporate offices. In order to make this as efficient as possible Hilti uses a territory-based approach for their Account Managers (AM). A territory is a geographic area, with each AM operating their own territory.

For the AMs to develop mutually value creating partnerships, each of Hilti's AMs must be experts. To enable this Hilti clusters the type of tools that each AM is responsible for selling by application type, this is known as the AM type (e.g. focusing on selling tools to work with concrete on exterior/fabric of a building vs tools to work with wood-based elements on the interior of the building).

Every year Hilti invests in new territories to drive sales. Mariah felt that this year adding territories was going to be the key to positioning Hilti for long term success. She also realised that any ideas she put forward were going to be highly scrutinised.

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The challenge

As Mariah was thinking about the issue, she realised that based on the previous data sets it may be possible to identify factors that are linked to the success of a territory. She wondered if there were any individual factors that were standalone indicators and dared to think if there would be amalgamation of data that could be modelled to establish and identify relationships between factors. Perhaps new data touchpoints could be created to support the development of sales strategy in years to come. If Mariah could find these factors and explain them, she felt that this could make an impact to the long-term success of Hilti.

A few days later and after some careful consideration she assigned your team to undertake analysis of the data available. She has instructed your team to undertake a detailed analysis of the data set made available to garner insight that may help devise a future sales strategy. Mariah would appreciate it if you could identify any potential opportunities that may align with the current direction and capabilities of Hilti. Therefore, your goal is to identify what would make a good data driven sales strategy that enhances future sales and redefines the makeup of determining a good sales territory. She is aware that the information derived from the data set provided may not be perfect and would therefore appreciate recommendations as to any potential touchpoints that could be created to improve Hilti's future data offering.

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Assignment Question

Assignment Part 1: Hilti Case study and Workshop Presentation – 70% of overall course mark.

The deliverable should be a **presentation of 12 minutes** in which the topics above are discussed and conclusions are made. In short, you will be undertaking a 'live' case study. The presentation must be much more than descriptive. It should be relevant to the course, drawing on models, theories and concepts that have arisen in the course and in the wider literature.

Assignment Part 2: Individual report (1500 words) – 30% of overall course mark.

Presentations should cover:

Hilti is a global leader in providing tools, technology, and service to the construction and building maintenance industries. Hilti operates a direct sales force model. To enable this, each sales resource is given a territory (a customer list based primarily on geographic logic). As with all established companies, there is a large component of historical influence on the approach. Despite its strong market position, Hilti is looking to enhance its sales performance through a robust data strategy that could enable the use of leads (non-confirmed potential business) and opportunities based (confirmed potential business) approach, allowing multiple sales resources to address potential business. You have been tasked with developing a data-driven strategy to help Hilti increase its sales.

For the presentation:

1. Strategic Sales Optimisation
   Propose a data-driven sales strategy that Hilti could implement to enhance future revenue growth. In your response, evaluate how advanced data analytics can be used to define and optimise sales territories. Consider geographic, demographic, and behavioural data in your approach, and explain how predictive modelling or clustering techniques could support strategic decision-making.

2. Customer Segmentation and Opportunity Identification
   Critically analyse how Hilti can leverage data analytics to uncover untapped sales opportunities and refine customer targeting. Include discussion on segmentation strategies, and the use of historical and real-time data to inform sales actions.

3. Data-Informed Decision-Making Across Organisation Levels
   Demonstrate how Haliti can utilise big data insights to support strategic, tactical, and operational decisions across different organisational levels (executive, managerial, and frontline sales). Provide examples of appropriate data visualisation tools, dashboards, or KPIs that would be useful at each level, and discuss the importance of aligning data outputs with business objectives.

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4. Implementation Considerations and Data Infrastructure
   When presenting your proposed data-driven strategy, assess potential implementation challenges such as data quality, integration, cultural resistance, or skill gaps. Identify the types of data sources (internal and external) that may be needed, any new data touchpoints that should be introduced.

Desired outcomes and supporting notes:

- Detailed analysis and discussion of the insights gained from the data analysis process provided and how your findings align with potential opportunities that can support the direction and capabilities of the organisation. Consideration should be given to any potential touchpoints that could be created to enrich current data offerings with the aim of enhancing products and services offered by Hilti.

The presentation notes should sketch the main points of your argument/presentation in more detail than is possible on the slides themselves. They should also give full citations of sources used. In the case of web pages, the citation should indicate the date visited and a full internet address. The slides and notes will be assessed.

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Marking Criteria

Your presentation will be assessed according to the following criteria:

C1) Understanding of Relevant Concepts and Literature (25%)

- Demonstrate a comprehensive grasp of key theoretical frameworks, models, and terminology relevant to data-driven sales strategies and analytics.
- Integrate up-to-date academic and industry literature, showing awareness of recent developments and debates.
- Articulate connections between concepts and their practical application in the context of Hilti.

C2) Quality of Analysis and Critical Reasoning (30%)

- Critically evaluate data, arguments, and evidence, identifying strengths, weaknesses, and limitations.
- Demonstrate logical progression of ideas, drawing reasoned conclusions supported by evidence.
- Address alternative perspectives and consider potential implementation challenges (e.g., data quality, organisational culture).

C3) Quality of Presentation and Response to Questions (20%)

- Present information in a clear, organised, and engaging manner with equal contribution across the team.
- Use effective visual aids (e.g., dashboards, charts, tables) to enhance understanding and highlight key findings.
- Demonstrate confidence and clarity in verbal delivery, maintaining audience engagement.
- Provide thoughtful, well-reasoned responses to audience questions, showing depth of knowledge and analytical skill.

C4) Quality of Evidence Used to Support Arguments (25%)

- Support all claims and recommendations with robust, relevant evidence drawn from credible sources (academic, industry, or company data).
- Demonstrate the ability to synthesise insights from multiple data sources, including both historical and real-time data.
- Provide clear references for all data presented, ensuring transparency and traceability.
- Reflect on the reliability and limitations of the evidence used, acknowledging areas for further investigation.

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Appendix

Figure 3: DX 100

Figure 4: Electro-pneumatic hammer drill, TE series

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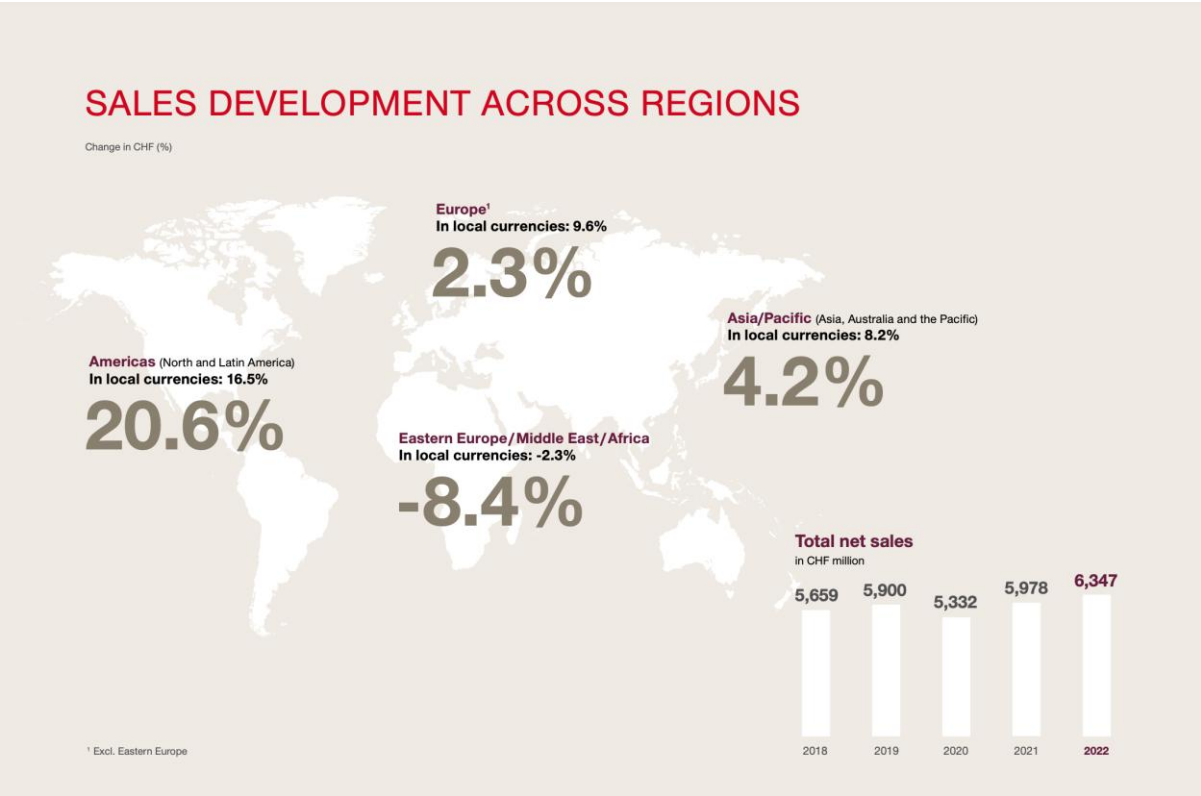

Figure 5: Hilti Development Across Regions

Figure 6: Hilti Outlook

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Analysis of Hilti Data Set

Memo:

As requested by Mariah, I enclose below the analysis of the sales data set. The data analyst team have done their best to retrieve, clean and analyse what data we had available, which admittedly is not up to date. It is not perfect, but it is all we have available. I hope this provides you with the insight needed to devise your strategy.

Best of luck with your presentation.

Regards, Mustafa Cuppa

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Data Description:

Table 1. Data Description

Label Notes	Description
Customer Base	Total count of customers in the territory
#FTC	# of First Time Customers
# EFA	# of Engaged, Frequent, Active customers (See activity class)
#E	# of Engaged
#F	# of Frequent
#A	# of Active
#P	# of Passive
#Non-EFA	# of customers not classed as EFA
#Focus	# of customers defined as "focus" (customers targeted to work with)
Estimated Market size	Value (in local currency), of the target addressable market. i.e. if all the customers bought all of their needed products only from Hilti, then that would be the sales number
#A	# of A class customer (See size class)
#B	# of B class customer
#C	# of C class customer
#D	# of D class customer
#E	# of E class customer
Sales CY	Current year sales
Sales CY-1	Prior year sales
Sales CY-2	Sales from two years ago

We are able to create the following new variables:

- Growth_1 = Sales CY/ Sales CY-1
- Growth_2 = Sales CY-1 / Sales CY-2
- Market_Penetration = Customer Base / EstimatedMarketSize
- **Calculate Growth Rate**: Growth_CY = Sales CY - Sales CY-1/ Sales CY-1

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Correlation: Pearson

Correlation Matrix: Identifying Drivers of Sales Performance

	Customer Base	#FTC	# EFA	#E	#F	#A	#P	#NonEFA	#Focus	EstimatedMarketSize	A	B	C	D	E	Sales CY	Sales CY-1	Sales CY-2
Customer Base	1.00	0.38	0.81	0.17	0.54	0.87	0.97	1.00	0.67	0.15	0.10	0.53	0.98	0.32	0.02	0.39	0.40	0.38
#FTC	0.38	1.00	0.42	0.18	0.26	0.44	0.43	0.36	0.48	0.20	0.12	0.31	0.35	0.04	-0.03	0.45	0.47	0.46
# EFA	0.81	0.42	1.00	0.52	0.79	0.97	0.85	0.77	0.86	0.15	0.08	0.65	0.77	0.24	-0.08	0.38	0.39	0.38
#E	0.17	0.18	0.52	1.00	0.36	0.35	0.20	0.12	0.53	0.11	0.13	0.36	0.12	0.03	-0.12	0.12	0.14	0.13
#F	0.54	0.26	0.79	0.36	1.00	0.67	0.58	0.50	0.66	0.17	0.08	0.66	0.48	0.10	-0.11	0.38	0.37	0.38
#A	0.87	0.44	0.97	0.35	0.67	1.00	0.90	0.84	0.82	0.13	0.06	0.59	0.85	0.28	-0.05	0.36	0.37	0.36
#P	0.97	0.43	0.85	0.20	0.58	0.90	1.00	0.96	0.70	0.16	0.10	0.52	0.95	0.30	-0.02	0.41	0.42	0.41
#NonEFA	1.00	0.36	0.77	0.12	0.50	0.84	0.96	1.00	0.63	0.14	0.09	0.49	0.98	0.33	0.03	0.38	0.38	0.37
#Focus	0.67	0.48	0.86	0.53	0.66	0.82	0.70	0.63	1.00	0.20	0.01	0.50	0.66	0.11	-0.16	0.37	0.38	0.37
EstimatedMarketSize	0.15	0.20	0.15	0.11	0.17	0.13	0.16	0.14	0.20	1.00	0.32	0.18	0.12	-0.03	-0.05	0.74	0.75	0.74
A	0.10	0.12	0.08	0.13	0.08	0.06	0.10	0.09	0.01	0.32	1.00	0.17	0.01	0.11	0.09	0.34	0.34	0.34
B	0.53	0.31	0.65	0.36	0.66	0.59	0.52	0.49	0.50	0.18	0.17	1.00	0.40	0.04	-0.08	0.48	0.48	0.48
C	0.98	0.35	0.77	0.12	0.48	0.85	0.95	0.98	0.66	0.12	0.01	0.40	1.00	0.25	-0.07	0.33	0.34	0.33
D	0.32	0.04	0.24	0.03	0.10	0.28	0.30	0.33	0.11	-0.03	0.11	0.04	0.25	1.00	0.79	-0.01	-0.01	-0.01
E	0.02	-0.03	-0.08	-0.12	-0.11	-0.05	-0.02	0.03	-0.16	-0.05	0.09	-0.08	-0.07	0.79	1.00	-0.08	-0.08	-0.08
Sales CY	0.39	0.45	0.38	0.12	0.38	0.36	0.41	0.38	0.37	0.74	0.34	0.48	0.33	-0.01	-0.08	1.00	0.99	0.99
Sales CY-1	0.40	0.47	0.39	0.14	0.37	0.37	0.42	0.38	0.38	0.75	0.34	0.48	0.34	-0.01	-0.08	0.99	1.00	0.99
Sales CY-2	0.38	0.46	0.38	0.13	0.38	0.36	0.41	0.37	0.37	0.74	0.34	0.48	0.33	-0.01	-0.08	0.99	0.99	1.00

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Table 2. Descriptive Statistics

Variable	count	mean	std	Min	25%	50%	75%	max
Customer Base	200	170.395	168.85	6	26	98	271.5	656
#FTC	200	11.9	28.54	0	0	3	11.25	244
# EFA	200	26.01	18.11	0	11	26	37	85
#E	200	5.465	3.00	0	4	5	7	18
#F	200	5.245	4.34	0	1	5	8	20
#A	200	15.33	13.59	0	3	14.5	22.25	61
#P	200	41.235	42.40	0	4.75	26	66.25	169
#NonEFA	200	138.64	154.51	0	10	67	222	581
#Focus	200	11.665	7.68	0	6	12	16	42
EstimatedMarketSize	200	26622686.05	55221253.95	0	4042394.434	13225152.98	26836704.02	589699899.6
A	200	8.89	5.67	5	6	7	10	52
B	200	26.815	26.20	0	9	17	40	110
C	200	129.815	155.10	0	1.75	68.5	210	589
D	199	1.331658291	4.03	0	0	0	2	51
E	200	2.08	13.12	0	0	0	0	148
Sales CY	200	477517.25	309922.18	222192	277405.75	372162	535637.75	1977563
Sales CY-1	200	459530.815	294395.66	213452	265008.25	356325	515994	1746443
Sales CY-2	200	448403.23	294949.82	196376	260262.25	342485.5	502855.25	1777762

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Clustering

Features important for Explaining K-Means Clusters

This figure shows the most important variables to create our clusters. Customer Base, EstimatedMarketSize, and #P (Passive Customers) are the primary differentiators.

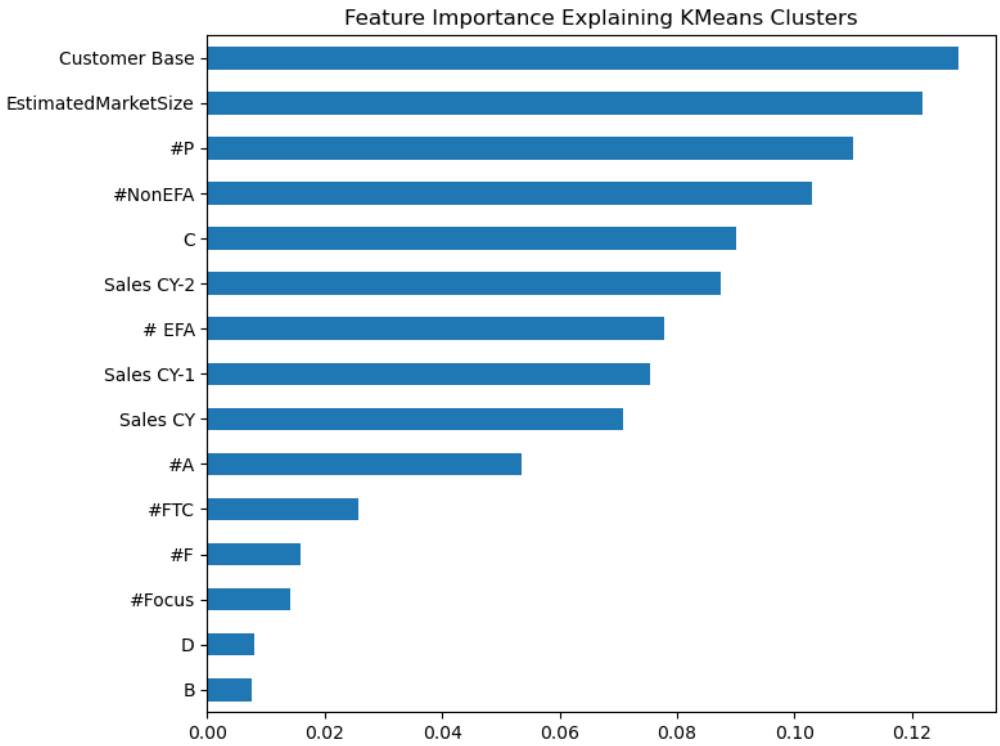

Figure 1. Feature Importance for Clustering Analysis

Cluster size

This figure shows the number of Territories per each Cluster.

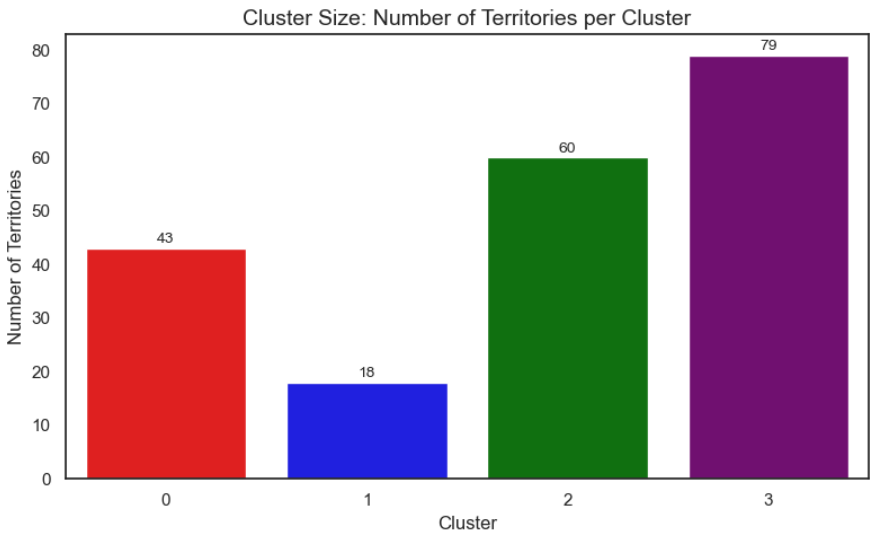

Figure 2. Cluster size

Cluster Centroid Profile

I created these clusters in a heatmap style, so comparisons between clusters will be easier.

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Note: Figures 13, 14 and 15 show the same.

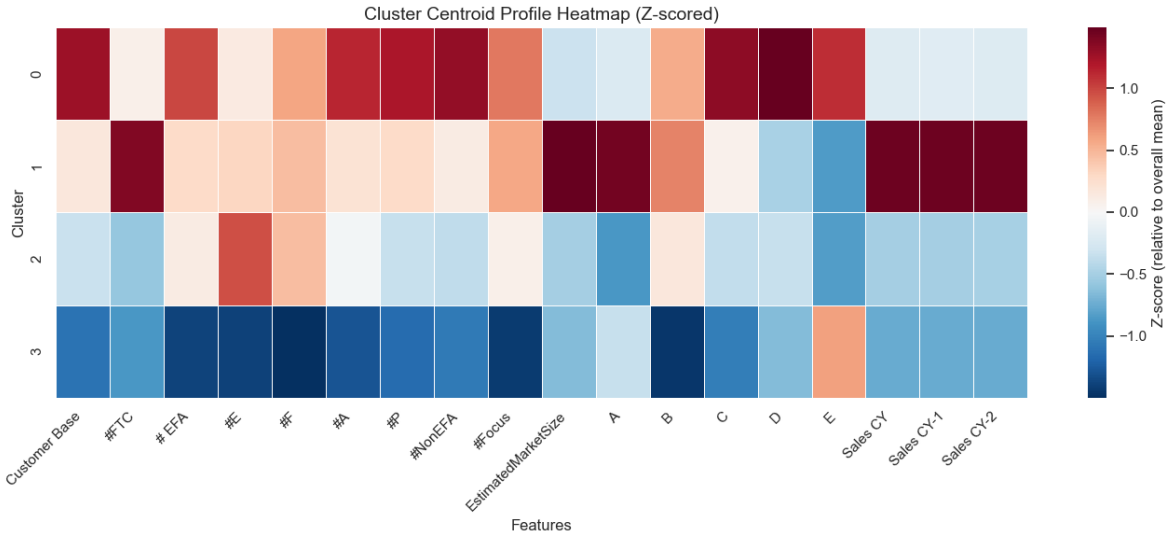

Figure 3. Cluster Centroid Profile

Cluster Profile

These figures provide another visualisation of the clusters.

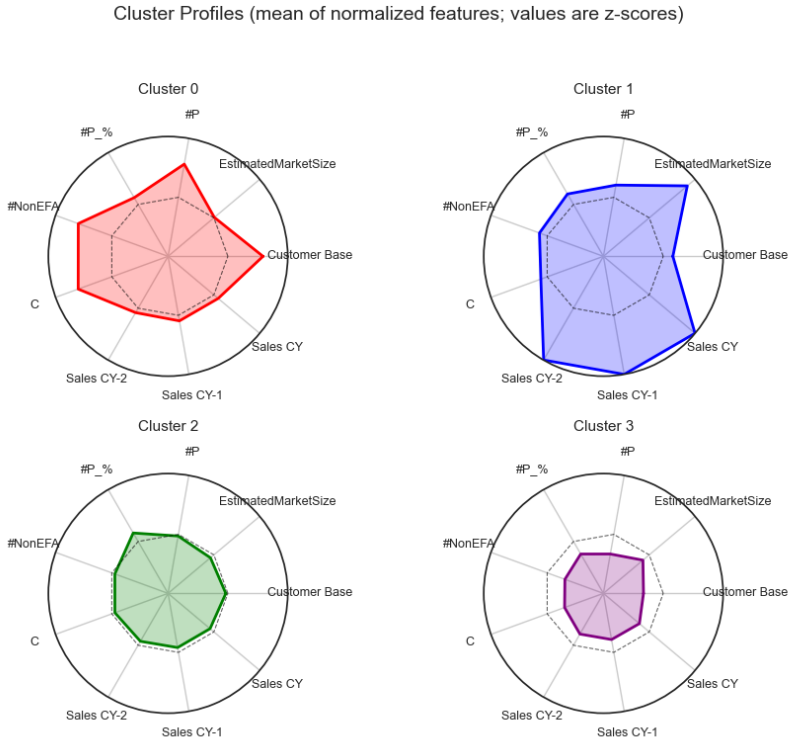

Figure 4. Another visualisation for clusters

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Parallel Coordination

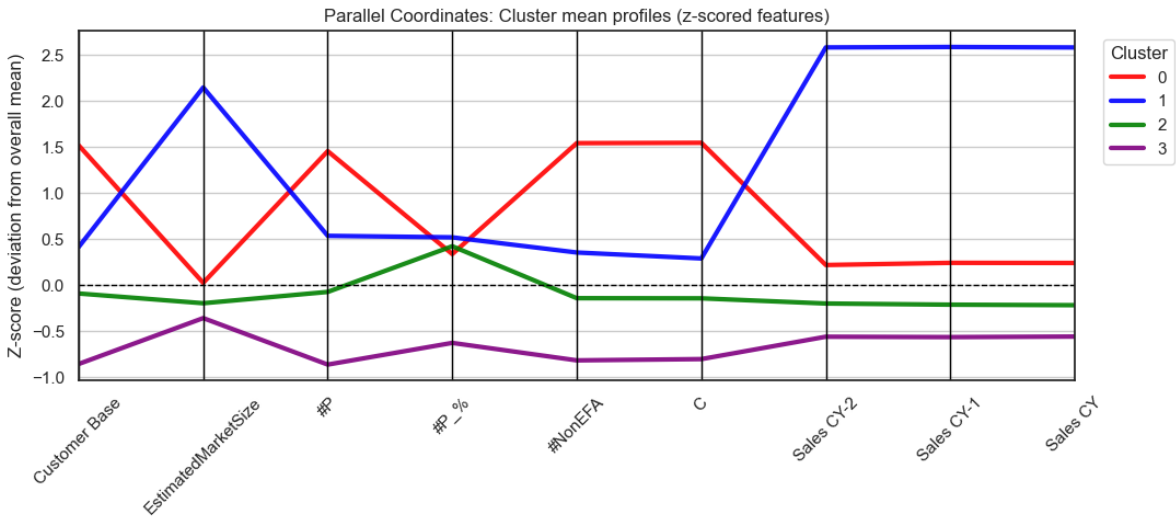

Figure 5. Parallel Coordination to visualise and compare clusters

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Visualisation:

Standardised Comparison (Z-Scores) for all variables

Figure 5 shows the standardised comparison of all variables. By converting raw values into Z-scores, we remove the "scale effect"—allowing you to compare a high-magnitude variable like EstimatedMarketSize (reaching into the millions) directly against a low-magnitude variable like #P. This plot will instantly reveal which metrics have the highest volatility and where the most significant outliers exist across your 200 territories.

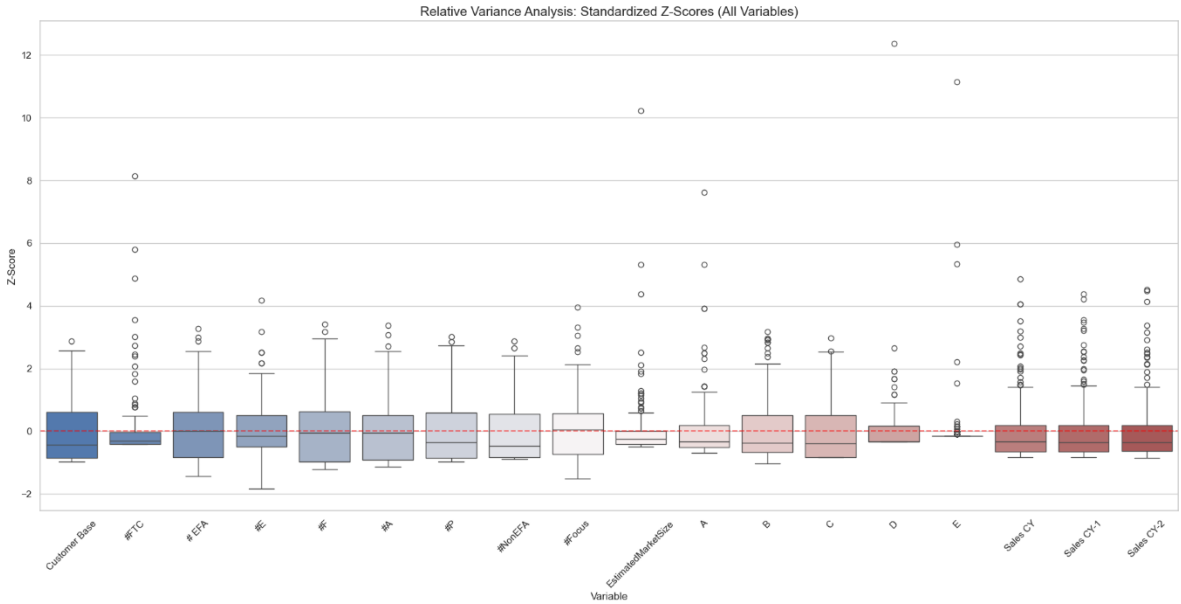

Figure 6. Relative Variance Analysis

Key Customer Segments

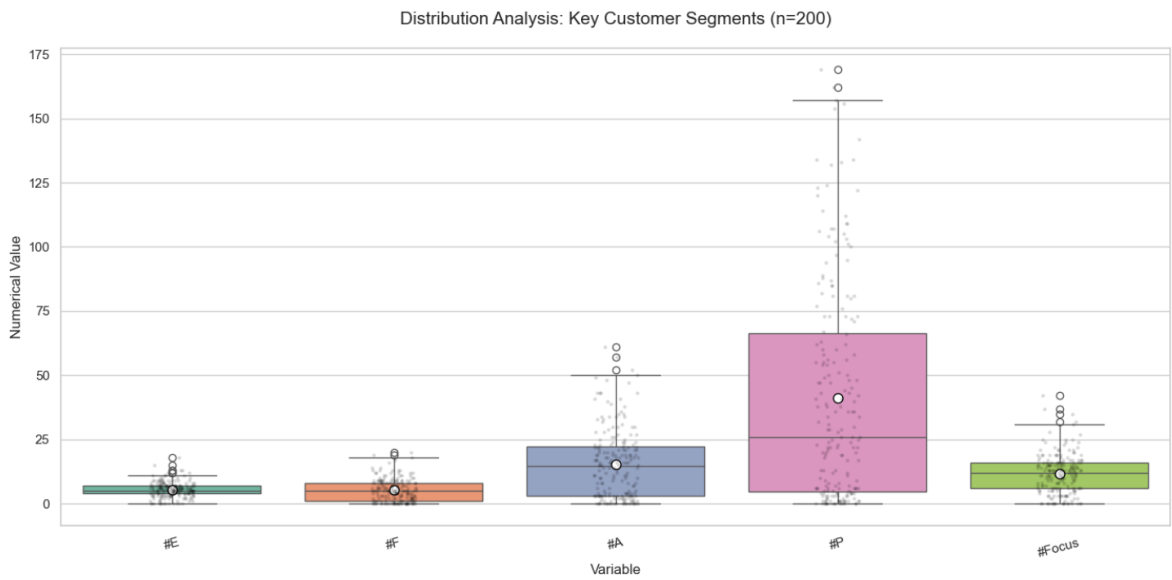

Figure 7. Distribution of Key customer segments

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Distribution of Market and Infrastructure

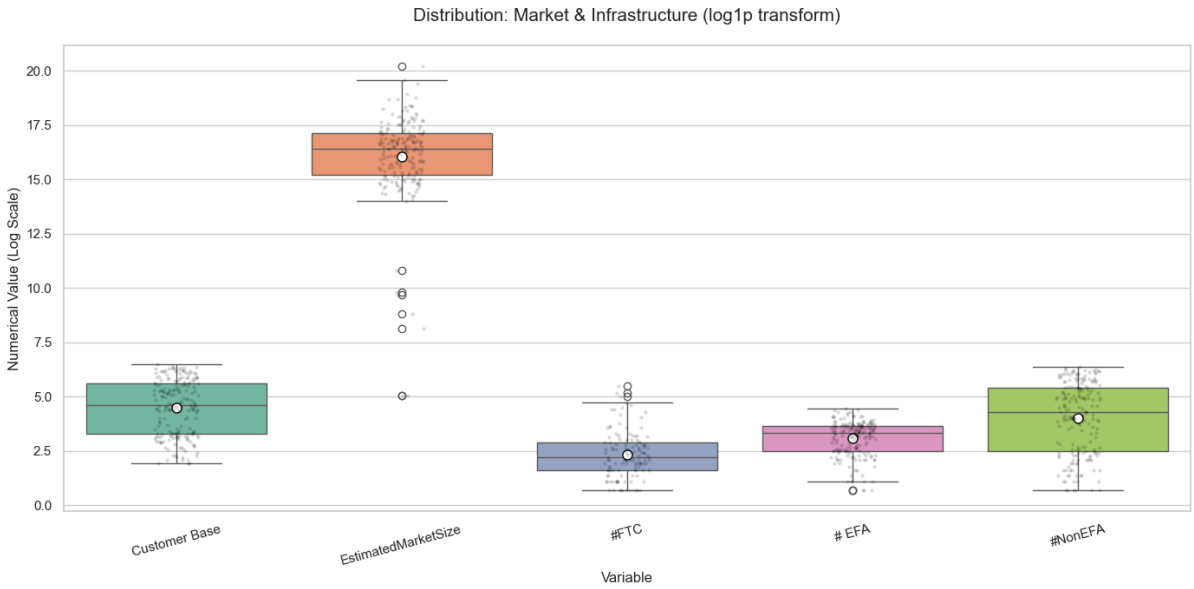

Figure 8. Distribution of Market and Infrastructure

Distribution Analysis of Raw Metrics:

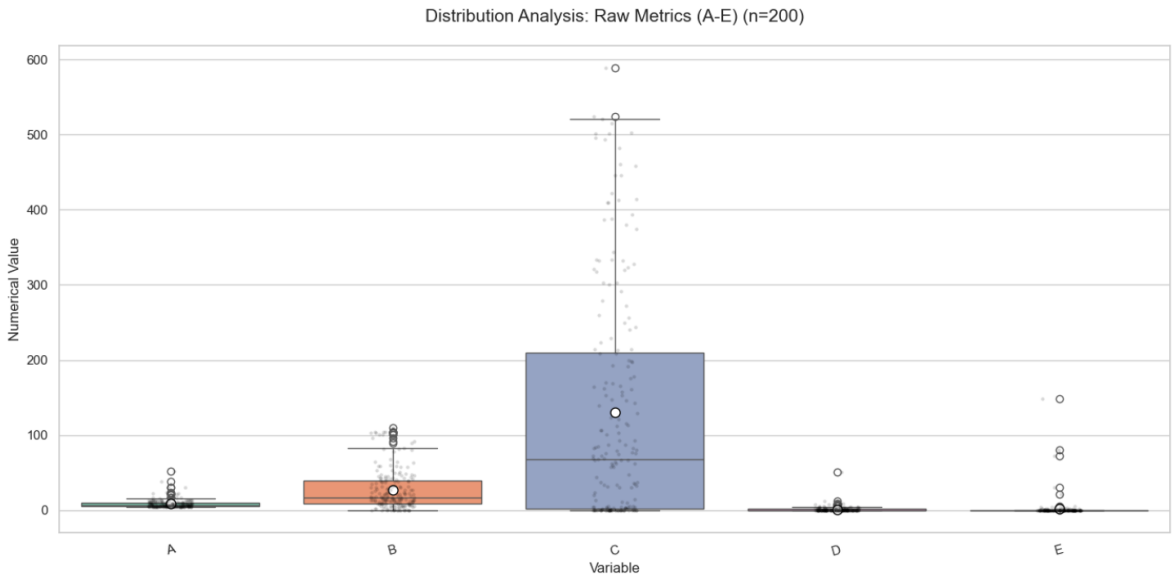

Figure 9. Distribution of Raw Metrics

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Customer Mix: Top 15 Territories by Sales (%)

Figure 10 below shows the sales for various customers for the top 15 Territories by Sales. This figure is a stacked bar chart showing the portion of each customer segment in those Territories.

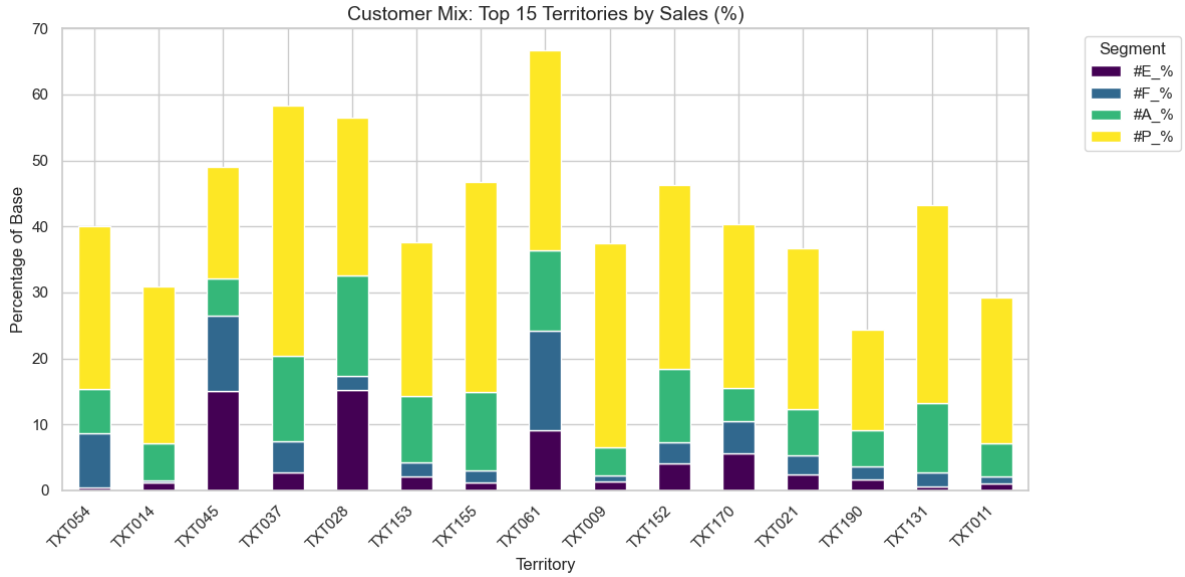

Figure 10. Distribution of customer categories for Top 15 Territories by Sales (%)

Density of Territories

Figure 11 employs a **Hexbin Plot** to visualise the relationship between the **Customer Base** and **Sales CY**. The Hexbin plot groups territories into hexagonal bins, using color intensity to represent the "density" or frequency of territories in specific performance zones.

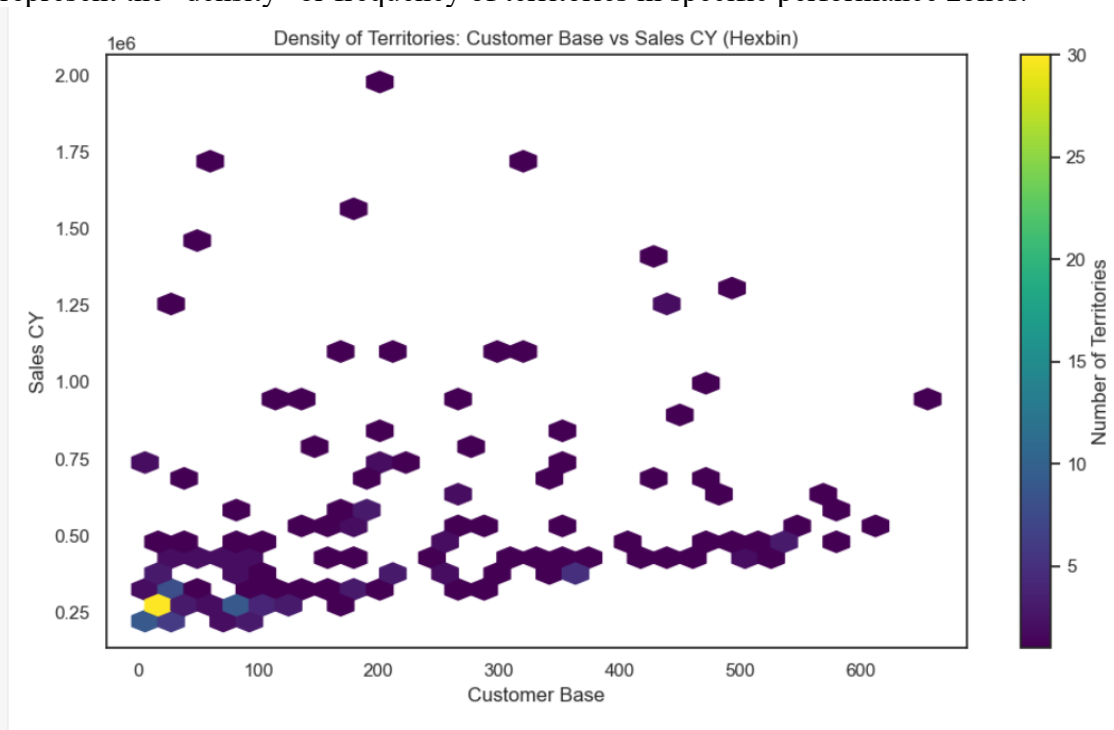

Figure 11. Density of Territories

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